The international restraint, however, did not pay off. This became obvious on 23 September 2008, when Ahmadinejad misused the stage of the United Nations for a speech that drew its inspiration from the *Protocols of the Elders of Zion*.

AHMADINEJAD'S UN SPEECH OF 2008

On 23 September 2008, speaking in front of the UN General Assembly, Ahmadinejad explained that "the dignity, integrity and rights of the American and European people are being played with by a small but deceitful number of people called Zionists." Although only "a miniscule minority" they "have been dominating an important portion of the financial and monetary centers as well as the political decision-making centers of some European countries and the United States in a deceitful, complex and furtive manner."

Even "the great people of America and various nations of Europe" are caught in the clutches of Jewish power: they "need to obey the demands and wishes of a small number of acquisitive and invasive people. These nations are spending their dignity and resources on the crimes and occupations and the threats of the Zionist network against their will."

Yet liberation is near. "Today," according to Ahmadinejad, "the Zionist regime is on a definite slope to collapse, and there is no way for it to get out of the cesspool created by itself and its supporters."[37]

Did this speech at the United Nations—an organization born out of the struggle against Nazi Germany and intended to embody the lessons of the Holocaust—provoke any scandal? Not at all. Shimon Peres, Israel's president, was the only head of state to state the obvious: Ahmadinejad "is a disgrace to this very house, the United Nations, its basic principles and values. His appearance here is already a shame."[38]

Instead, the president of the General Assembly, Miguel d'Escoto Brockmann, a 75-year-old Catholic priest who had served as foreign minister of Nicaragua from 1979 to 1990, personally thanked the Iranian President for his "excellent" speech and interrupted the session "to warmly, even enthusiastically, hug and kiss Ahmadinejad. Everyone in the hall clapped and cheered" wrote Nasrin Amirsedghi, "and here in Europe and everywhere is dead silence about it."[39]

The lack of reaction to Ahmadinejad's UN performance in Western capitals was indeed noteworthy. There were only three exceptions: The German and French foreign ministers, Bernard Kouchner and Frank-Walter Steinmeier, criticized Ahmadinejad's "blatant anti-Semitism," while then-Senator Barack Obama, in the middle of his election campaign, expressed

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